with Bairam Khan; they had resumed their pursuit of Sikandar Suri. It was Tardi Beg who remained in charge of Delhi, though several Mughal chiefs joined him in the city's defence. Among them was Bairam Khan's deputy, Pir Muhammad, and one of Humayun's Uzbek recruits, Abdullah.

The battle began rather well. The Mughal vanguard – including Abdullah the Uzbek – led a terrific charge that scattered Hemu's forward battalions, killed 3000 of his men, and captured 400 elephants. The vanguard galloped away in pursuit of the enemy – and plunder – but when they came back a little later, expecting the remaining army to have secured a victory, they found a scene of abject defeat instead.

What happened between the vanguard's triumphant chase and bemused return isn't clear. Hemu, it seems, took command of some 300 elephants and a battalion of soldiers and entered the fray. Meanwhile, the Mughal chieftains who remained with Tardi Beg were far less inclined to fight than those who had galloped away. Some, writes Abul Fazl, 'did not behave with courage', while Pir Muhammad simply turned tail and 'chose flight'. He did so, Abul Fazl continues, in order to 'ruin the Commander-in-chief-ship of Tardi Beg Khan' – and why he might have wanted such a thing will be clear soon enough. For the moment, however, Tardi Beg seemed willing to give up of his own accord; he, too, left the battlefield, and with victory in their grasp, 'there came [instead] a catastrophe'.

News of the rout reached Akbar on 13 October 1556, two days before his fourteenth birthday. The padishah was in Jalandhar, but quickly handed the campaign against Sikandar Suri to his aunt Gulbadan's husband, Khizr-Khwaja Khan, and marched south. It was in Sirhind, site of the great victory that had only just won them a stake in Hindustan, that Akbar's 'scattered Amirs came to salute him'.[24]

They brought with them an equally scattered resolve. According to Ferishta, a seventeenth-century historian, a 'majority of the officers' wanted to go home.[25] Hemu's army had too many men, too many elephants, and far too great a chance of defeating the Mughals. It was almost two years since Humayun had left Kabul; now, if only his son agreed, the soldiers and warlords who came with him might all return to their fiefs and families, enriched with plunder and possessed of their lives. Perhaps they were even a little nostalgic for the familiar, familial squabbling over Kabul. Delhi